

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY



HERITAGE CALL Idols inside the Chowringheenath temple; inset, the exterior on J.L. Nehru Road

revive the pilgrimage. Prime Minister Narendra Modi too referenced it in his February 26 *Mann Ki Baat*. The BJP rests its claim of historicity on scholarly research. One document it cites is Canadian anthropologist Alan Morinis's 1979 Ph.D. thesis, where he mentions Tribeni as a pilgrimage site in antiquity, though not a Kumbh. In a May 18 op-ed piece in *The Telegraph*, Morinis responded thus, "Someone with an agenda got hold of my dissertation and reworded the page where I discuss Tribeni to say what they wanted to say, not what I had written based on my years of research." He added that such "doctored documents" and "falsified research" to give the campaign a "higher level of sanctity and importance like a Kumbh" is being done to suit the political ends of "Hindu supremacists".

The BJP-RSS is undaunted. Prof. Mohit Ray of Jadavpur University, convenor of the state BJP refugee cell, says Bangladeshi author Ghulam Murshid's book *Bengali Culture: Over a Thousand Years* mentions Tribeni as a Hindu centre. "Where have the temples gone when the area is known by locals as Vishnu mandir? The murals on the mosque have embellishments similar to those found in temples," says Ray. There are those who hew towards this view. Says Sheikh Maqbul Islam, associate professor, St Paul's Cathedral Mission College, "As a junction of rivers, there's a high probability of Tribeni having been the site of an auspicious mela in the past. During my research, I discovered an antique Jagannath deity in that area. Probably the Vishnu reference comes from that." TMC Rajya Sabha MP Jawhar Sircar, however, is sceptical. "A small mela has been held at the trijunction, as happens at every sangam, but never a Kumbh, which happens only at Haridwar, Prayag, Ujjain and Nashik, according to tradition. It's inane to claim a Kumbh for Tribeni," he says.

Right in the heart of Kolkata, the BJP and its cohorts have discovered two old 'Hindu' strands they think are ripe for revival—both from well beyond the ambit of mainstream *savarna* Hinduism. One is the Chowringheenath temple of the Nath tradition, the other a site presumed to have had an iteration of a tortoise-shaped deity named Dharma Thakur, mostly associated with the poorer castes of western Bengal. "The Naths are a part-Shaivite stream. The local Naths are originally

BJP'S NEW DIRECTION

The party has been championing themes rooted in Bengal's local Hindu traditions. These include

- **Start a religious congregation in Tribeni Sangam, claiming it was the site of a Kumbh Mela centuries ago**
- **Renovate Chowringheenath temple; rename J.L. Nehru Road back to Chowringhee Road**
- **Resanctify pond in Kolkata's Dharmatala, now cast as the site of a forgotten temple to Dharma in the image of a tortoise**
- **Hindutva outfit Hindu Samhati Mancha publishes a calendar featuring 12 Islamic structures built allegedly after razing Hindu temples**
- **Organise congregations of sants in Kolkata to urge reading the Bhagavad Gita**